

Keep it simple: you're designing a home that works for everyone in the house, not just the person who loves settings screens.

The 30-minute audit (do this today)

Step 1: Create a room-by-room grid

Open Notes/Sheets and make a list like this:

Room → What you want → What you already have → Constraints

Example:

- Living room → Lights + movie mode + AC routine → 2 switchboards + Wi-Fi router nearby → false triggers if curtains move
- Bedroom → Night light + goodnight routine → fan regulator + bedside socket → wants physical switch control

Step 2: Photograph every switchboard

Take clear photos of:

- Each switchboard (front)
- The same switchboard with the plate removed only if you already know how and it's safe (otherwise skip and ask an electrician later)
- Any boards with fan regulators and 2-way switching



These photos are your “wiring map” for decisions later (smart switch vs smart relay vs smart bulb).

Step 3: Mark your “must automate” circuits

Pick just 5 for your Phase 1 build:

1. One primary light circuit
2. One plug/load (TV unit or bedside plug)
3. One motion use-case (passage/bathroom)
4. One comfort use-case (fan/AC)
5. One security use-case (door sensor/camera placement planning)

If you can't explain why a circuit is in Phase 1, it's Phase 2.

MISSION OBJECTIVE

By the time you finish this chapter, you should have:

- a room-by-room automation grid
- switchboard photos + notes (fan regulator / 2-way / neutral unknown)
- a list of inverter-backed circuits
- a shortlist of Phase 1 automations (5 circuits)
- a safety checklist for BIS/ISI verification using BIS CARE and the Standard Mark basics

Follow this logic to reduce complexity.

Switchboard reality in Indian homes

Most Indian homes aren't designed for smart automation by default. Switchboards typically combine:

- multiple light switches
- a fan switch + fan regulator
- sockets of different ratings
- sometimes two-way switching (staircase/passage)
- sometimes “mystery wiring” from renovations

The crucial question: Do you have a neutral at the switchboard?

Many smart switches/relays need a neutral wire behind the switchboard. Some “no-neutral” options exist, but they come with limitations (compatibility, flicker risk, minimum load requirements).

What to do right now: add a note beside every switchboard photo:

- “Fan regulator here”
- “Two-way switch here”
- “Neutral unknown / likely missing”
- “Metal back box” (can affect RF performance in some cases)

If you're unsure, don't guess. Neutral availability is often the difference between a clean install and an endless troubleshooting saga.

Plan for power problems

You haven't experienced electricity in India if it isn't erratic. Most homes are designed for outages, inverter lines, and voltage swings. In India, power isn't just “on/off.” Homes may have:

- inverter-backed circuits (usually lights + fans in key rooms)
- non-inverter circuits (ACs, geysers, kitchen heavy loads)
- surge events during restoration

Step-by-step: Identify what stays alive during a power cut

1. Switch on all lights and fans in the evening.